# 2

# The Stone Age—a Settled Life

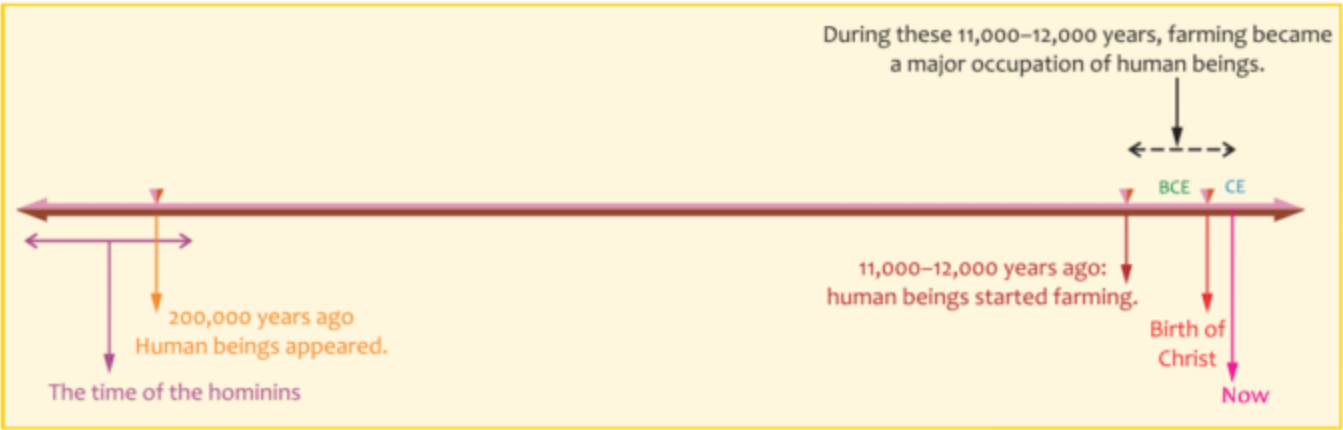
**Topics covered**

- The New Stone Age
- Metals are discovered
- Farming in India

A common Indian lunch is lentils (daal), vegetables, rice and chapattis. Draw red arrows to show how these come to us. One has been done for you.

| Lentils | Vegetables | Rice | Wheat flour for chapattis |
|---|---|---|---|
| ↓ | | | |
| Shopkeeper | Shopkeeper | Shopkeeper | Shopkeeper |
| ↓ | | | |
| Wholesaler | Wholesaler | Wholesaler | Wholesaler |
| ↓ | | | |
| Farmer | Farmer | Farmer | Farmer |

You buy from a shopkeeper, who buys from a **wholesaler** (who buys very large amounts to sell to shopkeepers) but it is farmers who grow almost all the food that we eat. Experts think that farming started many thousands of years after human beings first appeared on earth. The timeline shows you this.



# THE NEW STONE AGE

## The beginning of farming

As the hunter-gatherers wandered about in search of food, they probably noticed that many plants, such as wild wheat, had seeds that could be eaten. They also saw that if these seeds fell on the ground, sometime later new plants of the same kind began to grow there. They realized that they could gather such seeds and plant them near where they lived. Seeds from one or two plants would give them many plants and food for many people. This was a big **discovery**. It was the start of farming.

Wheat and rice are **cereals**—grasses whose seeds are used for food. (Left) Wild cereal plants that have few and small seeds; (right) cereal plants **cultivated** (grown) by farmers have more and bigger seeds. Early farmers learnt to produce such cereals. More food became available from each plant.

Hunter-gatherers had to search for food and eat whatever was available—they were *dependent* on the environment. Now human beings could plant the food they wanted to eat—they were *making changes in the environment*. Slowly people changed from hunting-gathering to farming. This did not happen at the same time all over the world.

Farming first started in West Asia. Later it started in South-East Asia in the region of the Mekong Delta.

**Did you Know?**

**Historians call that part of West Asia, where farming first started, the Fertile Crescent. The land was very fertile and crops grew easily. This area is mostly desert now.**

## TP Sources

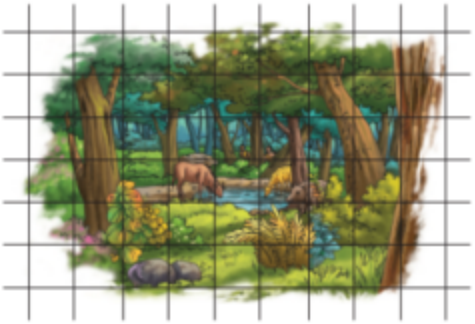
Archaeologists have discovered remains of villages. The huts of the first farmers were round or circular. They have also found grinding stones for grinding seeds into flour, pots for cooking or storage, seeds and tools used for farming. From all these sources, archaeologists have been able to guess what the lives of the early farmers were like.

Grinding stones—a bigger stone was hollowed out, so that grain could be ground in it with a smaller stone.

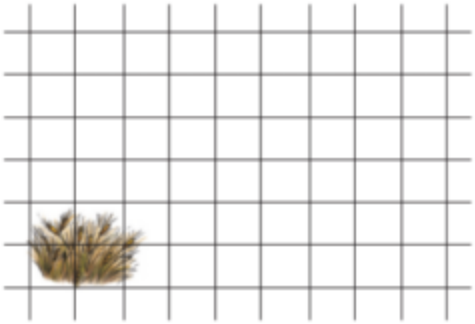
## Farming changed people's lives

Farming was a very important development in human history. It changed the way that human beings had lived for thousands of years. These are the ways in which the lives of people changed:

**Life became more settled.** Hunter-gatherers had to wander over a large area to hunt animals or gather food for a group of people (drawing 1). With farming, crops that provided food for the same number of people could be grown in a much smaller area (drawing 2). People lived near their crops to be able to care for them.



Drawing 1



Drawing 2

After studying sources, experts think that early villages may have looked like this.

**Small villages grew** as people's lives became more settled. The first huts were made of blocks of clay which had been dried in the sun. Many of these villages grew into towns and cities later.

**Animals were domesticated.** Dogs were the first animals to be **domesticated**. They were domesticated while human beings were still hunter-gatherers. Dogs were useful as guard animals and hunting companions. Later sheep, goats, cows and pigs were domesticated and provided milk, meat, wool and skin.

**Discuss**

Dogs were useful to early human beings. Is it similar to the way in which dogs are useful to us today?

**The food of the people changed.** Hunter-gatherers ate mostly meat and fish as well as fruits, roots and seeds. After they started farming, people ate mainly cereals, some vegetables, meat and milk.

Some pots were decorated.

**Many other things became possible.** Because of farming, enough food for the entire village could be grown by just a few people. Other people in the group had time to think about and do other things. For example, some people learnt to make clay pottery. The pots could be used for cooking or storing food.

**Trade developed.** Villages and towns produced more food and other goods than they needed. They began to exchange the extra goods with each other. This was the start of **trade** (trade=buying and selling of goods).

**The population began to grow.** Over hundreds of years, early farmers grew better and more crops, so gradually food became more easily available. The number of people increased.

**Did you Know?**

**Archaeologists have found many ancient images of mother-goddesses in several parts of the world. They think that early farmers worshipped the earth as a mother who helped them produce their food.**

Farming, which first developed about 12,000 years ago, is still the best way for human beings to get their food. It is a major occupation all over the world.

## Herding

All animals and plants that we use were at one time found only in the wild. Gradually humans domesticated those animals and grew those plants that would be useful. Some places were not suitable for growing crops. Here people kept herds of domesticated animals like sheep, goats or cattle that ate wild grasses and plants.

When the food for their animals was finished in one place, people moved to another where it was available. These people were **wandering herders**. In many places people lead similar lives even today.

## METALS ARE DISCOVERED

The Stone Age was followed by the Metal Age, when people discovered how to use **metals**. The earliest part of this period is the **Chalcolithic** or **Copper Age** when copper was discovered and used. In the beginning, when not much copper was available, it was only used to make small or precious things. Later, though people continued to use stone tools, copper was also used to make tools. However, copper is a soft metal, and the tools needed to be sharpened often.

A copper tool, nearly 5,000 years old, that was found in northern Italy. The red copper has turned green with age.

Later another metal, tin, was discovered in some parts of the world. This was mixed with copper to make **bronze,** which was stronger than copper. This period, in which bronze became the most commonly used metal, is called the **Bronze Age**. Many artefacts from the Bronze Age have been discovered, such as tools, cooking vessels, weapons, jewellery and decorative items. Copper and bronze are used even today to make jewellery, statues, utensils and medals.

Much later, iron was discovered, about which you will read in the next chapter.

**Did you Know?**

**Gold is considered the most precious metal because unlike other metals its colour never changes. The oldest gold artefacts found still have a lovely golden glow.**

## FARMING IN INDIA

Farming started very early in India too. Even today, most Indians live in villages where the main occupation is farming. In some places the methods of farming have not changed for centuries, but in others farming with tractors and modern tools is also practised.

An Indian farmer—his hoe (the farming tool in the picture) has a metal blade and wooden handle.

**Think and answer**

Which discoveries of early human beings do we still use today?

## Values and Life Skills

Early human beings lived in a very different world to ours.

- Were they less clever than people today?
- If we lived at that time, would we have been able to discover and do the things that they did?

When we think about people who lived in a different time, we should remember what that period was like. This will help us to understand them better.

## REMEMBER

1. Farming was a major development in human history.
2. Farming changed human lives.
3. Some people were wandering herders.
4. Metals were discovered during this time.
5. Farming started early in India. Millions of Indians are still farmers.

## NEW WORDS

| | |
|---|---|
| **Wholesaler** | a person who buys foods in large quantities from farmers to sell to shopkeepers |
| **Cereals** | plants such as rice and wheat, whose seeds or grains are eaten |
| **Cultivate** | to grow large amounts of plants that people can use as food or for other needs |
| **Discovery** | finding or learning something for the first time |
| **Domesticate** | to tame animals or grow plants for human use |
| **Metal** | material such as iron, gold, silver or copper, which is usually hard and shiny |
| **Bronze** | a metal made by mixing copper and tin |

## EXERCISES

**A. Choose the correct answer.**

1. People learnt to grow cereals that provided more food per plant/a small amount of food per plant.

2. Farming happened at the same time/different times all over the world.
3. We have no sources/several sources that tell us about early farming.
4. Clay pots were used as decorative pieces/for cooking or storing food.
5. Herds of animals belonging to wandering herders were fed cultivated crops/ate wild grasses and plants.
6. Bronze is made by mixing copper and tin/copper and gold.

## B. Write true or false.

Correct the false sentences in your notebook.

1. Farming started about 20,000 years ago.
2. The seeds of wild cereals were the same size as the seeds of cultivated cereals.
3. Farming first started in West Asia.
4. Herders moved to a new place when the grass and plants to feed their animals were finished.
5. Copper is a hard metal.

## C. Find the words.

In the puzzle, find the names of five animals that were domesticated and five metals that were discovered by early humans. Write them in your notebook.

| | | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Q | W | C | R | T | Y | K | P | V | G | U |
| Z | G | O | L | D | X | M | I | R | O | N |
| M | T | P | Y | U | I | P | G | C | A | M |
| N | L | P | K | D | O | G | S | K | T | B |
| S | H | E | E | P | X | V | F | H | S | J |
| B | K | R | A | D | F | T | S | O | V | C |
| V | L | K | J | H | G | I | D | I | H | O |
| C | X | Z | B | R | O | N | Z | E | B | W |
| Q | W | E | R | T | Y | U | J | H | D | S |

## D. Fill in the blanks.

Copy this table in your notebook. Fill the blanks to see how the lives of people changed with the coming of farming.

| | Hunter-gathers | Farmers |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Lifestyle | | Settled |
| 2. Food | | |
| 3. Homes | | |
| 4. Number of people | Few | |
| 5. Art and craft | | Pots made of clay |
| 6. Tools made of | | First stone, then metal |
| 7. The group | Everyone helped to find food. | |

## E. Answer the following questions.

1. Explain one main difference in the way in which hunter-gatherers and farmers lived with their environment.

2. What is the difference between wild and cultivated cereals? How is this useful for us?
3. Why was farming a major development in human history?
4. List the ways in which people's lives changed once farming started. Explain any two of these.
5. Who were wandering herders? Why did they need to wander?
6. Write a short paragraph about the Copper and Bronze Ages. Use these words: tin, tools, weapons, strong.

## THINGS TO DO

### A. Picture study

Study the map and name the following:

1. Two places where farming started before 9000 BCE
2. Two places where farming spread between 9000-7000 BCE
3. The places where farming spread between 7000-5000 BCE

### B. On your own

Try to imagine the lives of hunter-gatherers and of early farmers. Which of these would you have liked to live as? Write two sentences, beginning: 'I would have liked to live as a ..... because .....

### TP C. In a group

Imagine the past.
Early farming communities probably cooked over an open fire, surrounded by stones to prevent the fire from spreading. They did not have oil, spices or sugar, but they could grind the seeds of the cereals. They also had bowls. Talk about the things they might have cooked with their cereals, milk and meat. You can also do a short skit about preparing their food.

Cooking in a New Stone Age pot over an open fire

### WEBLINKS

The Stone Age:

- http://www.theschoolrun.com/homework-help/the-stone-age (Accessed on 20 July 2017)
- https://www.dkfindout.com/uk/history/stone-age/ (Accessed on 20 July 2017)